C-C bond distance in benzene (1.40 Å). Each carbon atom forms three σ bonds with three neighbouring carbon atoms using three of its valence electrons and the fourth electron present in the unhybridised p orbital forms a π-bond. These π electrons are delocalised over the entire sheet which is responsible for its electrical conductivity. The successive carbon sheets are held together by weak vander Waals forces. The distance between successive sheet is 3.40 Å. It is used as a lubricant either on its own or as a graphited oil.

Unlike graphite the other allotrope **diamond** is very hard. The carbon atoms in diamond are sp^3 hybridised and bonded to four neighbouring carbon atoms by σ bonds with a C-C bond length of 1.54 Å. This results in a tetrahedral arrangement around each carbon atom that extends to the entire lattice as shown in figure 2.5. Since all four valance electrons of carbon are involved in bonding there is no free electrons for conductivity. Being the hardest element, it used for sharpening hard tools, cutting glasses, making bores and rock drilling.

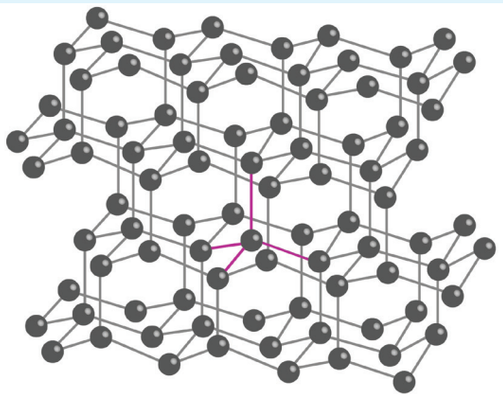


Figure 2.5 Structure of diamond

Fullerenes are newly synthesised allotropes of carbon. Unlike graphite and diamond, these allotropes are discrete molecules such as C_{32}, C_{50}, C_{60}, C_{70}, C_{76} etc.. These molecules have cage like structures as shown in the figure. The C_{60} molecules have a soccer ball like structure and is called buckminster fullerene or buckyballs. It has a fused ring structure consists of 20 six membered rings and 12 five membered rings. Each carbon atom is sp^2 hybridised and forms three σ bonds & a delocalised π bond giving aromatic character to these molecules. The C-C bond distance is 1.44 Å and C=C distance 1.38 Å.

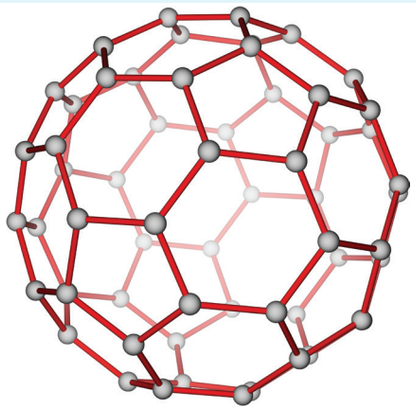


Figure 2.6 Structure of Fullerenes

Carbon nanotubes, another recently discovered allotropes, have graphite like tubes with fullerene ends. Along the axis, these nanotubes are stronger than steel and conduct electricity. These have many applications in nanoscale electronics, catalysis, polymers and medicine.

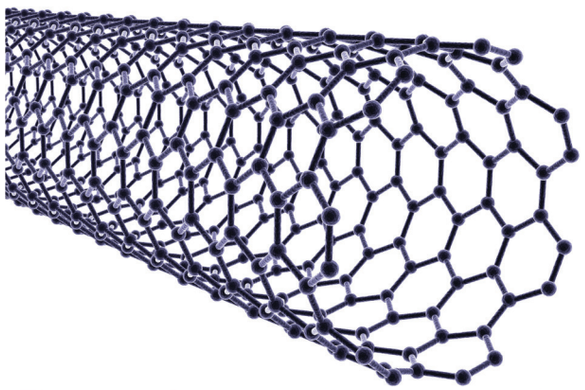


Figure 2.7 Structure of carbon nanotubes

XII_U2-P-Block.indd 42 04-01-2021 12:48:11